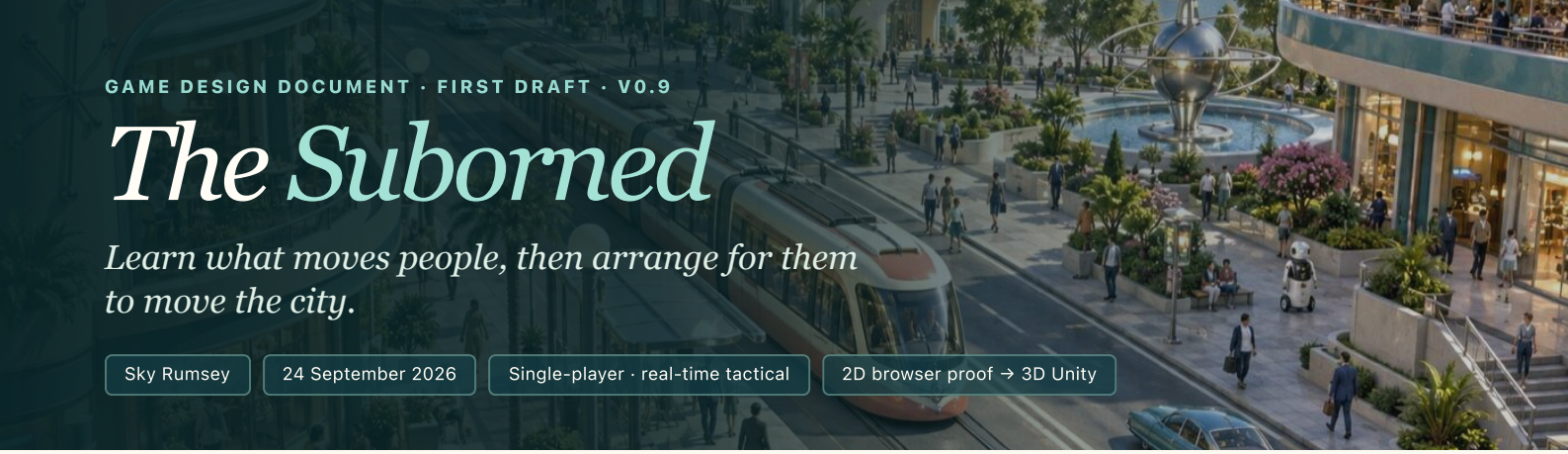


GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT · FIRST DRAFT · V0.9

The Suborned

Learn what moves people, then arrange for them to move the city.

Sky Rumsey | 24 September 2026 | Single-player · real-time tactical | 2D browser proof → 3D Unity

Status. Locked: pillars, core loop, the Records Office mission and offline, deterministic game rules. Open: three logic questions (RO-01 to RO-03, section 04), each answered by the 2D proof.

01 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The city is the instrument

Progress comes from understanding a person well enough to ask for something they can actually do.

Premise. You run a small, deniable fixer network in a bright retrofuturist city where trams, clerks and service robots keep perfect time. Clients hire you to move what the city guards (records, permits, access) without anyone seeing a crime. You have no army: only what you learn about people, what you can offer them and what you can hold over them. The tone is sunny civic optimism on the surface, with favours and debts underneath.

GENRE	CAMERA	MISSION	RUNTIME
Real-time tactical with soft-pause; single-player	Top-down 2D proof; isometric 3D in Unity later	One city block, one objective, about 12–15 minutes	Authored data and fixed rules; no live AI calls

PILLAR 1

Subvert people

Discover their work, access, loyalties, ambitions and vulnerabilities. Choose an approach that suits the person.

PILLAR 2

Orchestrate the city

Combine people, schedules, vehicles, buildings and robots in one timed chain of cause and effect.

PILLAR 3

Adapt to consequences

People remember how they were treated. Influence fades, resentment grows and institutions learn.

Signature moment. Help Harold the clerk clear a debt and he later carries a file out for you. Threaten him instead and he complies once, then refuses the next request, remembers who asked and warns the guard. The reaction is authored, repeatable and readable on screen.



Look and feel (visual research, not a game screenshot). Cream curves, teal enamel, coral transit accents and warm glass. In play, teal marks what you know, coral marks risk and gold marks opportunity; workwear silhouettes show each person's job. The proof uses a clean top-down block in this palette, while walkable areas and access stay authored game data.

02 GAME MECHANICS

Observe, influence, arrange

A person is a character with capabilities and memory, not a generic converted unit.

Observe → **Investigate** → **Influence** → **Coordinate** → **Live with the result**

What the player sees

A top-down block in real time. A **routine strip** shows the next two minutes of every schedule you have observed: the guard's round, Harold's break, the next tram. Click anyone to open their **dossier**, with confirmed facts in teal, suspicions in grey, and trust and memory below. Three **exposure pips** sit at the top of the screen.

What the player does

Click to move your field operative; press Space to soft-pause and queue orders. Watch or follow people to confirm clues, then choose a lever, an approach and a request. The person answers *yes*, *counter* or *no*, then acts within their own routine while guards, trams and robots keep moving.

Four approaches, four memories

APPROACH	NEEDS	EFFECT NOW	WHAT THE PERSON REMEMBERS
Help	A known need, e.g. Harold's debt	Slow: costs time or money first	Trust +2; larger requests accepted later
Pay	Cash	Immediate, one-off	No change in trust; the next price rises
Pressure	Confirmed leverage	Immediate compliance	Trust −2; the next request is refused and may be reported to the guard
Appeal	A known loyalty or ambition	Works only if the request fits it	Trust +1

Each person has access, trust (−3 to +3), suspicion and a memory of how you treated them. Requests are **small** (look away), **medium** (open a door) or **large** (carry the file). A person agrees when they have the access and trust or leverage covers the size of the request; otherwise they counter or refuse and say why.

First mission · Records Office

A client needs a sealed file from the Records Office before the archive shreds it at close (18:00 in game, about 12 real minutes). The block holds the office, a café, a service lane and a tram stop. Harold the clerk, a café worker and a maintenance technician follow authored routines and one guard patrols. Citizens create the opportunity; your single field operative only collects.

1 · Read the block
Watch the café, the office entrance, the service lane and the guard's 90-second round.

2 · Find leverage
See Harold meet a collector at the café; follow the collector to confirm the debt.

3 · Arrange the window
Route A: Harold carries the file out on his break. *Route B:* the technician opens the service door and the café worker draws the guard away while the operative takes it.

4 · Carry the consequence
Leave with the file. Witnesses, evidence and each person's treatment carry into the next mission.

Win: extract the file before close. **Lose:** the file is shredded, or exposure reaches 3. Exposure rises by 1 when a guard or witness sees a restricted act or a refused threat, and falls by 1 after 60 seconds unobserved, so a slip at 1 or 2 can be recovered.

How missions and areas connect

Mission template: an objective, fair clues, people with the right capabilities, at least two independent routes, a failure threshold, a recovery path and a lasting consequence. **Area template:** public and restricted zones, entrances, observation points, schedule anchors, transit links and a security response. Named people keep their state between areas. New missions recombine existing people before adding mechanics, and a new area earns its place by creating a new decision.

03

AI ARCHITECTURE · BUILD-TIME CREW

One lead, clear owners

Fifteen agents build the game; none of them runs inside it. Each row says what the agent makes and what a player notices because of it.

AGENT	WHAT IT BUILDS	WHAT THE PLAYER NOTICES
Aster LEAD · ALL PHASES	Keeps the goal tree and this GDD, splits work into single-owner contracts, and accepts or returns each result.	Every feature traces to a pillar; no half-finished system reaches the build.
Motive DESIGN · 2D	Writes the rules for how each person reacts to each approach and how that memory changes later requests.	Harold helps after a favour and refuses after a threat.
Fable DESIGN · 2D	Writes each person's background, voice and reply lines from Motive's rules.	A refusal gives Harold's own reason, not a generic "no".
Waymark DESIGN · 2D	Builds each mission graph: objective, fair clues, two independent routes and a recovery path.	The debt can be found by watching, and a failed request still leaves a way through.
Keel ENGINEERING · 2D	Owns the ID catalogue, data schemas and save format that every other agent writes into.	What Harold remembers survives saving, loading and the next mission.
Latch ENGINEERING · 2D→3D	Builds the playable scene (operative movement, dossiers, the request flow), then the Unity version.	Orders and replies respond instantly and behave the same in 2D and 3D.
Pulse ENGINEERING · 2D	Implements the timed routines for people, the guard, trams and robots.	The guard's round and Harold's break repeat reliably, so a window can be planned.
Splice ENGINEERING · 2D	Builds import and validation tools that reject any clue, action or ID missing from Keel's catalogue.	Every option offered can actually happen; there are no dead-end requests.
Vela PRESENTATION · 3D	Models the 3D city blocks in Blender from the approved 2D layout.	Doors, lanes and sightlines stay where the player learned them in 2D.
Forma PRESENTATION · 2D→3D	Makes the occupational characters: 2D sprites first, rigged and animated 3D later.	A clerk, a technician and a guard are recognisable at tactical zoom.
Glint PRESENTATION · 3D	Sets lighting, shaders and rendering budgets for the Unity build.	The city keeps its sunny mood without hiding people or doors.
Glyph PRESENTATION · 2D	Designs the dossier, routine strip, exposure pips and accessibility options.	Known facts and suspicions never look alike, and risk is always visible.
Chime PRESENTATION · 2D	Designs the audio cues for routines, replies and exposure.	A tram bell or a door buzz tells the player a window has opened without looking.
Suture QUALITY · 2D	Runs scripted checks and new-player playtests against the proof's pass criteria.	Both routes are confirmed finishable by someone who has never seen the map.
Redline QUALITY · 2D	Reviews code and profiles each build.	No broken states or frame drops while the whole block is moving.

How they work together: one change, end to end

Assess	Assign	Review	Continue
Aster picks the next objective: "Harold refuses after a threat."	Motive's contract names the collector clue and the archive actions Harold is allowed.	Suture replays the threat-then-request path; Redline checks the memory flag.	Aster accepts the result or sends a fix back to its owner.

One agent, one wow

Motive writes Harold's reaction table. Fable writes his lines, Keel fixes the schema, and Latch and Pulse implement the memory flag and behaviour. Aster accepts the reviewed result. The same table then drives every later request made to Harold.

Autonomy and memory

Aster makes routine calls without the human director. It escalates only for a pillar change, new paid spend, a release, a destructive action or an unresolved conflict. Anima keeps each agent's identity and work history across sessions, so handoffs survive restarts.

04 TECHNICAL STRATEGY

Prove the loop before 3D

The same game rules are tested cheaply in 2D, then carried into a richer Unity presentation.

Pipeline and engine

Aster briefs the owners. Owners produce versioned artifacts (rule tables, lines, mission graphs, sprites), reviewers return findings, and Aster merges them into one canonical GDD and data set. The proof is built in **Phaser** for fast browser playtests. People, actions, clues, mission states and save flags live in plain JSON, so the Unity build replays the same cases. Generated art is only a visual layer; walkable areas, interaction points and routes are authored data.

Biggest constraint: cross-agent consistency

A plausible handoff can give Harold an action, clue or access right that the mission graph does not contain, and the result is a request the game cannot honour. **Response:** Keel keeps one ID catalogue and typed output schemas; Splice rejects unknown IDs on import; Suture plays the full path; Aster resolves conflicts before any data is merged.

Token budget: one planning and review pass

WORK	MODEL	INPUT	OUTPUT	EST. COST
Design and architecture	Claude Opus 5.5	27,000	7,200	$0.25
Build planning	GPT-6 Sol	16,000	4,000	$0.07
Presentation briefs	Claude Opus 5.5	18,000	4,600	$0.16
Independent review	Claude Opus 5.5	10,000	2,000	$0.08
One pass		**71,000**	**17,800**	**≈ $0.57**

Semester envelope: 4 milestones × 3 passes = 12 passes, about 1.07 million tokens or $7. Coding and image generation are metered separately for each session. All figures are estimates until usage is logged.

API constraints

- **Model lanes.** Claude Opus 5.5 handles the lead, design, narrative, art briefs and player-facing QA; GPT-6 Sol handles engineering, tools and code review.
- **Context.** Opus 5.5 accepts 1M tokens and GPT-6 Sol 1.05M, but each call is capped at a 30,000-token slice of the GDD plus approved IDs, so no pass depends on the full window.
- **Price.** Opus 5.5 costs $4 per million input tokens and $20 per million output; GPT-6 Sol costs $2 and $10 (list prices, September 2026).
- **Rate limits and failures.** Calls are queued at review gates, with one owner per surface at a time. Token use is logged per call, and a failed call resumes from the last saved artifact.
- **Grounding.** Every prompt carries the approved IDs, task scope, output schema and reviewer. Agents mark unknown facts instead of inventing them.
- **Runtime.** Neither playable version calls a model; the game runs offline.

Roadmap

1 · One block	2 · Connected places	3 · Small district	4 · Unity 3D
Prove the social loop, two routes and one remembered consequence.	Add the tram avenue and repair forecourt; the same people move between them.	Combine retrieval, diversion and exposure missions as institutions adapt.	Rebuild camera, spaces and presentation, replaying the same rule and mission cases.

The proof passes when a new player finds the debt clue, completes the objective through either Harold or the service route, understands a refusal, and sees a later reply changed by how a person was treated. **Open questions:** RO-01, can the collector clue be found without hints? RO-02, are the exposure values above fair in play? RO-03, does the service route truly work without Harold? We will also test whether one field operative weakens the social focus.

Prices: Anthropic model documentation; OpenAI GPT-6 Sol model page (checked 24 September 2026).